



LAKE MEAD behind Hoover Dam, shown days before July 4, is the country’s largest reservoir. It’s 27% full.

## A NEW LOW IN STATES’ WATER CRISIS

Colorado River’s two big reservoirs drop to record levels. Experts warn users of cuts.

By IAN JAMES

Lake Mead and Lake Powell, the country’s two largest reservoirs, have fallen to their lowest combined levels on record, a grim marker in the deepening water crisis across seven states that depend on the Colorado River.

The two reservoirs are now lower than the previous record in 2023, researchers say.

“It’s a hell of a milestone,” said Jack Schmidt, director of Utah State University’s Center for Colorado River Studies. “Really a teaching moment to all of us of the severity of the crisis.”

U.S. Interior Secretary Doug Burgum met with governors of the seven states virtually Tuesday and said his agency will release a plan to deal with water shortages next week.

Lake Mead near Las Vegas, the country’s largest reservoir, is 27% full. Lake Powell on the Utah-Arizona border, the second-largest, is at just 23% of capacity. If it drops 33 more feet, water won’t reach its intakes to generate hydroelectric power.

Schmidt and five other researchers wrote in a white paper that the new low underscores the urgency of using less water. They predicted the reservoirs will keep setting records every day until snows come and bring the next seasonal pulse of runoff.

It’s unclear whether the strong El Niño conditions this year might provide some relief. The latest three-month forecast by the National Weather Service predicts above-average rainfall along the river and in much of the Southwest through October.

[See Reservoirs, A8]

## Silicon Valley workers push back against AI

By QUEENIE WONG

Silicon Valley residents are increasingly trying to stop the advance of artificial intelligence, even as the region attracts hundreds of billions of dollars in investment to expand the technology’s reach.

Companies and workers around San Francisco Bay sparked the global AI explosion. Now, the nation’s tech hub also sits at the center of an intense and growing revolt against its ability to cause harm and replace humans.

Hunter Glenn joined a group of protesters outside the San Francisco headquarters of AI trailblazer Anthropic on Monday because he is worried that AI poses a threat not only to jobs but also to humanity.

He was laid off as a copywriter soon after his company started using AI tools.

“They didn’t tell me ‘we’re replacing you with AI,’ but that’s the impression I got,” he said.

Tech workers and activists have staged protests this month throughout the area, sounding the alarm that AI will become tougher to control as it grows more powerful.

Prominent economists, tech leaders and researchers have warned that AI could transform the economy for better or worse, bringing large-scale job displacement. And people are pushing back against new data centers in their communities.

[See AI, A10]

## LAUSD plays up stability

Amid budget crisis, new chief stresses the positive

By HOWARD BLUME AND FRANCESCA PINNEY

Los Angeles schools Supt. Andrés E. Chait made a calm official entry Tuesday into his new job, emphasizing rising student test scores and “a sense of belonging” that binds school communities — and looking beyond a projected financial crisis, declining enrollment and legal attack from the Trump administration.

In his first annual “state of the district” speech, held

at Garfield High in East Los Angeles, Chait, 51, talked of stability, hard work well done and school district family values. He tamped down concerns over a looming multibillion-dollar deficit, immigration raids that have depressed attendance and enrollment, and the sudden change in leadership that left him in charge of the nation’s second-largest school system.

Chait became acting superintendent in February and accepted the permanent job on June 24. Eight

days later, the Los Angeles County education office — a financial oversight agency — said recent school board budget decisions “erode confidence” in the district’s ability to avoid bankruptcy.

The Los Angeles Unified School District had overextended itself in newly approved union contracts and faces a deficit that, if unchecked, would grow to \$3.585 billion by June 30, 2029, the county said. This year’s budget calls for spending \$20.6 billion.

[See Chait, A7]



KAYLA BARTKOWSKI Los Angeles Times

STUDENTS dance as part of Supt. Andrés Chait’s “state of the district” event.

## Pentagon seeks \$70 billion as Iran war drags on

Hegseth raises cost estimate for conflict. Senators from both parties are skeptical.

By ANA CEBALLOS AND MICHAEL WILNER

WASHINGTON — The Trump administration urged Congress on Tuesday to approve roughly \$70 billion in emergency defense funding to sustain U.S. military capabilities amid its escalating war against Iran, warning that without it the Pentagon could face “critical shortfalls” disrupting its readiness.

The request comes as the United States and Iran have traded strikes for 10 consecutive days in a renewed conflict, deepening concerns in Washington over an expanding war that could inflame the global economy and trap the president in a quagmire.

The collapse of a ceasefire agreement and the sudden resumption of war have raised alarms within the Pentagon over its ability to protect U.S. forces and assets in the Middle East over

a prolonged conflict, with defensive munitions in dangerously short supply, two Defense Department officials told The Times.

Yet the administration is facing bipartisan skepticism from lawmakers over the continuation of a war unpopular with a vast majority of Americans, over which they have had little oversight, and that in recent days has led to deaths of U.S. soldiers.

Those tensions became clear as Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth and Gen. Dan Caine, the chairman of the Joint Chiefs of Staff, testified before the Senate Appropriations Committee to make their case for the tens of billions of dollars and offer their first in-depth public remarks about the war since May.

Hegseth told senators the United States is at a “moment where we cannot afford inaction,” while Caine argued the funding request is coming to Congress “while time is still on our side.”

“It is critical that we stay ahead of our adversaries and we must have the funds before we are out of time,” Caine said.

[See Hegseth, A6]



ANNA MONEYMAKER Getty Images

DEFENSE Secretary Pete Hegseth said the war is now expected to cost \$37.5 billion, up from \$29 billion.

## U.S.-Iran fighting stymies diplomacy

Attacks and Yemen rebels’ Saudi blockade complicate efforts to revive interim truce.

By JON GAMBRELL AND MUNIR AHMED

ISLAMABAD, Pakistan — A 10th straight day of attacks between the United States and Iran across the Middle East on Tuesday overshadowed diplomatic efforts in Pakistan to salvage an interim ceasefire deal that has collapsed.

Iranian Interior Minister Eskandar Momeni visited Pakistan, a key mediator in the conflict seeking to revive diplomacy. But it was unclear what new arrangement might be reached to end the war, which lately has become a battle for control over the Strait of Hormuz, a waterway vital to world energy supplies.

Speaking from the Oval Office, President Trump gave a dim view on possible talks, saying the U.S. had “no interest in meeting.” He signaled that U.S. forces could soon target an area of Iran close to one of its main

sites for enriching uranium. With negotiations and shipping through the Strait of Hormuz largely stalled, both sides have sought to gain leverage by targeting civilian infrastructure in the region relied on by millions of people.

A barrage of U.S. strikes hasn’t loosened Iran’s grip on the strait, through which about one-fifth of the world’s crude oil and natural gas was shipped before the war.

The U.S. continued its airstrikes Tuesday on the Islamic Republic, and Iran attacked a tanker in the strait, forcing the crew to abandon the ship. Iran also kept up attacks against U.S. allies in the region. Sirens in Bahrain and Kuwait warned residents of incoming projectiles.

The escalation pushed energy prices higher. The international benchmark for

[See War, A3]

### Trump threatens Pickaxe Mountain

President’s focus shifts to the fortified Iranian nuclear facility as fighting resumes. **NATION, A4**

### Feds withhold Medicare payments

Agency blocks California from \$867.5 million, citing fraud concern over rise in care spending. **NATION, A4**

### Grisly photos at singer’s hearing

Prosecutors show pictures of a dismembered girl in their case against D4vd. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

### Weather

Mostly sunny.  
L.A. Basin: 84/69. **B6**

**Markets** ..... **A10**  
**Opinion Voices** ..... **A12**

### Cleanup coming for skyline icon

Graffiti Towers are set to be sold, bringing an end to the infamous tagging. **BUSINESS, A9**

For the latest news, go to **latimes.com**.



By SALVADOR HERNANDEZ

Electric bike crashes and injuries are increasing at a rapid pace across California, and many of those getting hurt are children 14 years old or younger, according to a new study by researchers at UC San Diego.

E-bike riders were involved in at least 4,035 collisions in California from 2018 to 2024. Although the num-

ber of collisions involving traditional bicycles remained relatively stable during the seven-year period, collisions involving e-bikes increased dramatically.

No e-bike crashes involving injuries were noted in the study in 2018 and 2019, but by 2024, 1,566 were recorded in California.

“E-bike injuries are rapidly increasing in California and are associated with a higher severity of injuries

compared with traditional bicycles,” according to the report, which was published Friday in the journal Trauma Surgery & Acute Care Open.

The researchers from UC San Diego collected numbers by analyzing data from the California Highway Patrol’s Statewide Integrated Traffic Records System. The data include traffic incidents and reports submitted by law enforcement agencies across the state.

E-bikes have quickly grown in popularity and are becoming more common on city streets, parks, trails and bike paths.

Their proliferation has raised challenges for police, lawmakers and parents.

E-bikes can go faster than traditional bikes and are often ridden by children and teenagers who may not have the experience to handle the speed.

Medical officials have

[See E-bike, A8]